moved further north in India. They realized that Rahul Gandhi had transcended partisan politics and was symbolizing a national movement, a messianic figure committed to the nation's welfare.

The Bharat Jodo Yatra managed to galvanize not only the senior leaders, but also witnessed remarkable dedication from younger party members. The unifying spirit of the Yatra transcended the often factional nature of the Congress in Kerala. It united leaders and rank-and-file members, shifting the political narrative in the state. The Congress is now positioned as a staunch defender against fascist forces, often described as being even more left-leaning than the left, according to independent observers.

Rahul Gandhi now stands as the pivot of this national movement, the leader who can challenge Narendra Modi, the BJP, the RSS, their corporate partners in crime and their agenda. The Congress party must rebuild itself from the grassroots and transform not only the organization, but also its guiding principles to effectively combat this growing challenge. It needs to let go of tendencies that have alienated the common man, the *aam aadmi*. Moreover, the party should make itself more appealing and inspiring to the youth, women and a cross-section of the population.

The Left Parties: Missed Opportunity to Embrace India's Cause

The initial response of the leadership of the left parties in Kerala, particularly the CPI(M), to the Bharat Jodo Yatra was marked by criticism and subtle insinuations. However, as they witnessed the overwhelming response of the people and noticed that the Congress refrained from launching political attacks on the Left Democratic Front (LDF) in Kerala, focusing instead on the Yatra as a response to the nation's challenges, the LDF adopted a more passive stance. They refrained from creating roadblocks, which, as the ruling party in Kerala, they could have done. This was a silent acknowledgement of the Yatra's significance.